

Listen First

A Parent's Guide to Getting Kids to Actually Listen

PREVIEW EDITION - 4 of 12 chapters

Why "just listen" doesn't work

Most advice about getting kids to listen focuses on the wrong moment: what to say after they've already ignored you. By then, you're both frustrated and it's too late to prevent the standoff. The four techniques in this preview work earlier - before the instruction even leaves your mouth - so it lands the first time far more often.

None of this requires yelling, bribing, or counting to three. It requires changing four small habits. Here they are.

1. Connect Before You Correct

A child's brain has to feel safe and connected before it can process an instruction. Giving a direction from across the room, mid-tantrum, or the instant you walk in the door skips this step entirely - which is why it so often gets ignored.

Try this instead:

Get physically close, at their eye level, and make brief contact - a hand on the shoulder, their name said gently - before you say what you need. This takes under five seconds and dramatically raises the odds the instruction is actually heard.

2. Say Less, Not More

"Okay, so I need you to put your shoes on, and grab your backpack, and don't forget your water bottle, and hurry up because we're late" is five instructions stacked into one breath. A young child processes one at a time. The rest becomes noise.

Try this instead:

"Shoes on." Wait. Once it's done: "Backpack." One instruction, one word if possible, said once. Resist the urge to repeat it three different ways - repetition trains kids to wait for the third, louder version before responding.

3. Offer a Choice, Not a Command

Commands invite resistance because they remove all control from the child. A limited choice keeps you in charge of the outcome while giving them genuine control over how they get there - which is usually all the resistance was actually about.

Try this instead:

Instead of "Get in the bath now," try "Do you want to walk to the bath or hop like a bunny?" Both options end with them in the bath. Only one invites a fight.

4. Follow Through, Calmly, Every Time

Kids learn what actually happens, not what you say will happen. If "we're leaving in five minutes" is never actually enforced, it stops meaning anything - and neither does anything else you say after it.

Try this instead:

State the boundary once, calmly, and then follow through exactly as stated - even if that means leaving with one shoe on. The consistency, not the severity, is what builds the habit of listening the first time.

This preview covers 4 of the 12 chapters in the full Listen First guide, which also covers sibling conflict, public meltdowns, screen-time transitions, and age-specific scripts from toddler through preteen.